MOUNTAIN INN
A room with a mountain view at Taj Guras Kutir; right, Soi & Sake, the Asian cuisine restaurant at the resort; below, a grand Sikkimese thali made with local produce







It is a rainy 4.30 pm and a monk, his maroon robes creating their own private ritual with the flickering lamps, conducts a prayer. He chants in front of a large bay window, in a lounge full of windows, all facing the mountain range ahead. By his side, a young Taj employee creates immaculate vibrations on a Tibetan meditation bowl. The monk is praying to the goddess we call Mt Kanchenjunga, though she can't be seen on this cloudy evening.

I am completely in tune with the ceremony. I feel reverential towards the Kanchenjunga not only for her glorious silver self, and her status as the third highest peak in the world, but also in my capacity as a puny mortal who has been denied a glimpse by the capricious goddess on previous trips to Gangtok. Like the priest, I can't see her; like him, I am prayerful. Let it be *this* time.

When the ceremony is over, the lady from the resort patiently teaches me how to play the meditation bowl and when I finally succeed, I hug her. We giggle like a pair of mynas.